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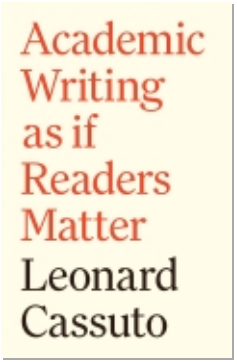
Introduction



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Introduction

The Primal Scene of Academic Writing

All academic writers begin their journeys in the classroom. There they write for an audience of one person: the teacher.

Professors read students' work as evaluators. The evaluator has a specific job: to read their students' writing from beginning to end and assess it. (The job usually includes writing a response, too, but let's put that task aside.)

The central quality of the evaluator's job is thoroughness. She will read your work closely and completely. One of my former teachers, Edward Tayler, described it this way:

> With proper allowance for human weakness, you may reasonably hope for an attentive, sympathetic reading of every word you write—a kind of reading you may not reasonably hope for ever again.[1]

This kind of careful reading is a gift. As Simone Weil put it: "Attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity."[2]

But there's another concrete and essential reason why student writers may expect this careful attention: *the reader is getting paid*.

The evaluator's position as a paid reader is the exact opposite of the general reader's. General readers pay for the privilege of reading (by buying books or magazines, or subscribing to websites), and they feel no obligation whatever to be thorough. General readers will quit reading if they don't enjoy what they're

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doing, or if they don't feel they're getting something worthwhile out of the experience.

Every academic writer begins by writing for a captive audience: someone who is literally being paid to pay attention. Long before they set foot in graduate school or venture beyond it, academic writers spend years getting used to a reader who can't be distracted or discouraged, because that reader receives cash to read to the end.[3]

The main problem with writing for a captive audience is that it teaches us to take the reader's attention for granted. Student writers learn to be long-winded because they know—consciously or not—that their reader won't quit on them. They can begin a mile away from their topic and slowly work their way in. Or they may supply three examples where one will do (usually to fill up pages to reach an assigned word limit—tell me you've never done that), all because they trust that the reader will dutifully trudge through.

When student writers sit down to write for a paid audience of one, they enact the primal scene of academic writing. Like other mythical moments of originary consciousness—the fall of Adam and Eve, the Freudian discovery of civilization's discontents, and so on—this primal scene portends disappointment. It points to its own future failures.

But academic writing's primal scene begets far worse than prolixity. Its worst symptom is that it promotes a disconnection from, and disregard for, the reader.

If you know that your readers will stay with you no matter what, you don't have to worry too much about how you treat them. Instead of working to care for the reader, academic writers are taught by their earliest experience that readers are unconditionally invested. They require no consideration because they're already on the hook. That unfortunate lesson invites all kinds of bad writing, and with it the genesis of this book.

Like all primal scenes, the academic writer's beginning ripples forward to affect the future. Academic writers don't leave our primal scene behind. Instead, we re-create and repeat it. (I know I

have. I've made many of the mistakes that I warn against in this book.) After we pass the stage of writing for an audience of one, we go on to make many of the same bad moves when we write for wider audiences, often with the hope of getting published. Unexamined bad habits become enshrined. Care for the reader remains an afterthought—or no thought at all.

The primal scene thus stays with us ever after. Writing a paper for your undergraduate professor, a dissertation for a committee, and an article for publication are really three versions of the same exercise, separated by time and experience. Like the professor who reads a student's work, the evaluators of journal and book submissions are paid readers also.*

I'll have more to say presently about how to create a more generous relation between the academic writer and the academic reader—a lot more. I'll also give unvarnished advice about other writing matters.

In a book full of rules and principles, here's the first one:

Even if the reader is being paid, it is better to write as though he or she were not. Write to earn your reader's attention, and then keep on earning it.

On Rules (and Rule-Breaking)

I wrote this book for two main reasons. The first is that academic writing has a bad public reputation, with painful results that affect us all. Imagine standing up to announce that most scholarly books and articles are boring, impenetrable, or worse. The response

* Wait, I hear you say: article evaluators typically aren't paid. That's technically true (though the readers of submitted book manuscripts usually are compensated). But evaluators who teach at colleges and universities are paid for what is ambiguously called "service," a category that includes this kind of work. There's also an implied quid pro quo that promotes focused attention: I read the work of my peers with care so that they will do the same for me. Whether through the influence of pay or barter, the author of a scholarly submission may expect a careful and complete reading just as the student author of a seminar paper does.

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would be a collective shrug—because that sentiment has become a virtual cliché. Most academic writing is assumed to be bad. Every academic writer starts out in that deep hole.

I would characterize the problem differently. I find that most academic writing is unfriendly and ungenerous. Too many academic writers treat their readers indifferently, or worse. But our readers are the reason that academia—and academic writing—exist in the first place. Poor academic writing contributes to a larger lack of respect for academic work.

That disrespect is everybody's business. If higher education is a public good—and it must be—then it must interact fruitfully with the wider public. Yet the writers working in higher education mistreat various publics, including our closest community of fellow academic readers. Too much academic writing sends an unfortunate message to readers: you don't matter.

Every academic writer—whether student or teacher—represents all the others. Yes, each writer is a free agent. But academic writers also take part in a shared system of inquiry. We matter to each other—and to our readers—as a group. As I will suggest, that's why we must write well: because our work matters to more than just ourselves.

Which brings me to my second reason for this book: because reading most academic writing is work. I mean that in both the literal and the figurative sense. Reading academic writing is literally part of many people's jobs. Figuratively, doing that job can be a slog—it's work to get through the stuff. We (and by "we," I don't mean just professors and students, but anyone engaged in serious intellectual inquiry) may read academic writing as part of our jobs, but that doesn't mean that reading it has to feel like work. Put simply, most academic writing is reader-*un*friendly.

This unfriendliness problem also affects all of us—and again, I don't mean only people who work at colleges and universities. Academic writing, like the intellectual mission it demonstrates, badly needs renovation, lest it be dismissed and torn down by a public that is increasingly skeptical about it. The public judges us by what we say, starting with how we say it. I hope that this book

will help individual writers. I hope, too, that it will lead to writing that helps readers. And, finally, I hope that it will also aid the larger effort to reinforce the frayed relations between town and gown.

What about AI?

As I was finishing this book, artificial intelligence (AI) abruptly arose as a frightening specter on the writing landscape. Language Learning Models such as ChatGPT are already provoking questions of whether writing will soon turn into the esoteric practice of a small population of specialists. The role of Generative AI will surely shake out in the coming years, and I offer my own early thoughts on that subject in the appendix to this book. The capacities of AI already amaze—but they don't include conscious, connected communication.

The idea of writing as communication lies at the center of this book. A writer who does a good job forges a connection with the reader, and sympathetic understanding flows back and forth. Too much academic writing lacks writerly effort to create that connection. Nor is the problem limited to academic writing. Today's public sphere is filled with too much noise and not enough actual communication.

If academics are to fulfill their role as teachers, then we ought to model communication—a connection between writer and reader—at every level of the academic enterprise. AI can't do that because it lacks sensibility. This must be the job of actual human writers. Any writing that goes beyond "souped-up auto-correct" (as economist Paul Krugman has described AI) requires that the writer seek understanding and connection with other humans.[4] How to connect is a skill that's not limited to writing—but writing can teach it. And we can use more of it in the world.

~~All of this brings me to . . . cooking. Perhaps you've read the magazine *Cook's Illustrated*. The format of a typical *CI* article is: "I set~~

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CHAPTER 1

The Care and Feeding of the Academic Reader

> When I write, it's to connect.
> I have a total responsibility to the reader. The reader has to trust me and never feel betrayed.
>
> —PETER SCHJELDAHL[1]

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Relationship Advice: The Clasp of the Hand

As a writer, you enter into a relationship with your reader. You're someone with information who wants (and maybe needs) to share it, and your reader is someone who wants (and maybe needs) information. Another way to put this: you are different from your audience, but each of you seeks something from the other.

Here's the guiding message of this book: *Care for your reader*. Create a friendly and generous relationship with your audience.

Here's the central metaphor in this book: imagine your relationship with your reader as you reaching out and clasping your reader's hand.

The handclasp describes a meeting of two minds. More important, it captures the idea of care. You need to create a mutual relationship with your audience in which you seek to understand each other. In this process, you try to comprehend the needs of your audience, while your audience tries to comprehend your argument.

All writers have to figure out what their readers do and don't know. It doesn't make sense to lecture a professional tennis player on how many points it takes to win a tiebreaker, any more than you would need to remind a European historian that the Treaty of Westphalia broke the power of the Holy Roman Empire.

But it's dangerous to assume too much background for your reader. Because scholarly writing centers on the idea of expertise, this pitfall is ever-present. For graduate students, who are seeking certification as experts, it's a constant danger. ***Be a generous expert.***

Let me put it another way: many graduate student writers are afraid of appearing to talk down to specialist readers who have more experience than they do. The inexperienced writer fears that these experienced readers will think the writer believes them to be simpletons, and so the writer skips "unnecessary" background.

That's a misplaced fear, because even specialists don't mind being oriented. When academic writers (including a disproportionate number of dissertation writers) skip over the basics, they lose a chance to introduce themselves and show the reader where

their ideas come from. That lack of background produces pernicious results.

As the writer, you're creating a place for the reader to inhabit. It should be one that the reader is happy to occupy. When you explain stuff the reader may already know, you show how you understand this shared knowledge by how you teach it. Imagine you're writing about the bluesman Muddy Waters. You might say, in effect, I'm a blues fan, and I see Waters in a certain way. Insiders—aficionados of blues, and also of gospel and soul—will appreciate knowing where you're coming from, and they'll learn more about your point of view by watching you cogently explain something they already know to readers who lack that background.

When a writer omits these explanations out of concern that the reader will be bored (or worse, offended because she already knows it), the reader never gets comfortably situated. A few years ago, I read a graduate student's description of Kurt Vonnegut's "famous attempt to write an 'anti-glacier' book." In fact, the reference is not famous, or even known outside of microspecialist niches. I certainly had never heard of it before my student brought it up.

From this unexplained reference, a reader might infer that the writer won't deign to address a lightweight who doesn't know this "famous" commonplace. That brushoff would encompass approximately 99 percent of scholarly readers, to say nothing of nonscholars. No writer wants to alienate that much of their readership, obviously. But that's what happens when you don't think clearly about the needs of your audience.

Youthful anxiety may create the need to talk down to the audience—to prove that you know stuff. That's a mistake, and it can persist long after dark hair turns white. Wielding expertise like a cudgel is a skill that academic writers may refine over time, witnessed in these two examples from the work of senior scholars:

> As everyone is aware, development today is a field of action in a "new regime of unequal international relations."[2]

> By now we are all familiar with discussions of "unexpressed language," neatly codified in recent years as a sociolinguistic phenomena [*sic*].[3]

The writers' declarations that "Everyone is aware" or "We are all familiar with" translate to "Surely you must know." Well, what if I don't? Scorn likely won't motivate me to find out. ***Please don't be mean to the reader***, whose only sin is the desire to learn things.

Academic writers are teachers. Most academics learn to teach in classrooms while in graduate school, but I'm not talking only about that specific activity. *Academic writing is also teaching*: you are teaching your research to someone else.

When we talk about teaching, we should talk about learning. What you intend to teach with your writing matters less than what your readers take from it. You may write for specialists or for wider audiences, but either way, you need to think about the needs of your readers. That Vonnegut reference implies that the reader is an expert already. It's as though you're trying to teach someone to drive, but instead of starting with a typical automatic-transmission car, you begin with a motorcycle with manual transmission, no pedals, and the clutch mounted on the handlebar. Don't assume that the reader can just climb aboard one of those and zoom off alongside you.

Bad scholarly writers reside too deep inside their own heads and not enough in the reader's. If you invoke the theorist Fredric Jameson's idea of a "postmodern hyperspace" without explaining it, then no one who hasn't read a particular work by Jameson can know what this abstraction means. If you proceed without supplying that explanation, you pull away from the curb with only Jameson's careful readers as your passengers. An unfamiliar reader may get a sense of what you're talking about, but her comprehension will be limited. So you see what's at stake if you don't forge the understanding you need. As a writer, you will lose a large portion of your potential readership.

CHAPTER 2

Everything Is a Story

The Argument Is a Story

Human beings are storytelling animals. We use stories to understand the world and ourselves, and we tell stories to communicate that understanding.

Even when we don't realize we're doing it, we're telling stories. The instruction booklet explaining how to jump your car's dead battery is a story. The recipe you follow to make dinner is a story. And so is the academic essay you read or write—or at least it should be.

In academic writing, the argument makes an essay an essay. Argument is the currency of the realm, the measure of what a piece of writing is worth. Most of all, argument is what academic readers read for. Knowing how to make a good argument (or thesis) is an academic writer's central skill, which is why it's taught as the main goal of first-year English ("Composition"), the gateway course to college education.

Too many academic arguments get in their own way. Some arrive cloaked in scaffolding that needed to be stripped away before delivery. Others lack the structural integrity to stand atop their own evidence—or they topple due to lack of that evidence. Others groan under the weight of unnecessary digressions that drag them down and make them hard to follow. Arguments easily

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turn convoluted, involuted, and lead-footed. This chapter will show you how to make arguments with clean lines, clear structure, and strong foundations.

Here's the first rule for how to do that: remember that ***all arguments are also stories***. The way to make an argument sticky is to keep in mind that you're telling a story. That's my argument—and my story—and I'm sticking to it. This chapter is a story about how to tell a better story.*

Remember that a story need not have a whimsical plot. In academic writing, it usually should not. Jerry Seinfeld's streaming series *Comedians in Cars Getting Coffee* is an example of a simple linear story. Every episode unfolds in the same way: Jerry and his guest get into a car, they buy coffee, and they drive back. That's a story, because even a structure that basic creates narrative expectation. That expectation can then be exploited; in this case, it becomes a skeleton that the interesting stuff—the banter between the comedians—is attached to. *Comedians in Cars* is literally story-driven.

What kind of story should an academic writer tell?

The answer: a straightforward one. To illustrate, let's start with the counterexample of Billy Wilder's classic film noir *Sunset Boulevard*. The movie begins with a murder victim floating in a Hollywood swimming pool. "Maybe you'll like to hear the facts, the whole truth," says the narrator in a voice-over. "If so, you've come to the right party."

Wilder makes a couple of noteworthy moves here. First, he signals that he's going to tell a story that explains the dead body in the pool. Second, he doesn't tell you everything about it. Most important, he's not telling you who the dead man is. (If you want to know, here's a spoiler.[1]) The deliberate omission serves the story's purpose: like most crime stories, *Sunset Boulevard* has a surprise ending.

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* The reason that encyclopedia entries make such dull reading is that they generally don't tell a story. They just pass along information as efficiently as possible.

The deceptive approach of crime stories—which often trick the audience—doesn't make much sense for scholars who write to teach their work to readers. Spoiler alert, then: academic writers should *not* try to write their own *Sunset Boulevard*. But you can still customize Wilder's two opening moves:

First, write from your main idea, not to it. If there's a body floating in the pool, start with it. Don't describe the pool first. In other words, start with whatever your writing is most deeply about. If you're ultimately trying to explain the function of the narrator in *Uncle Tom's Cabin*, start with the narrator and save your relevant but secondary historical riffs on abolitionism, proslavery, and domestic feminism for the body of your piece.

The second half of this rule is: ***Let text invoke context, not the other way around***. If you're explaining literature, start with literature. But if you're doing history (say, offering a fresh historical analysis of antislavery thought inspired by *Uncle Tom's Cabin*), start with history, though you can use a line or two from the novel as an opening frame if it takes you to the history right away. Putting your main idea up front and then stepping back to take in the context frames that main idea. This move makes it immediately and structurally clear to the reader what's most important to you, and what overarching objective will organize that follows.

Furthermore

Think of the primacy of text over context as though you were a painter making a portrait. You should sketch in the sitter before you turn to the background, because the sitter is the reason for the picture, the focus of the viewer's eye.

Second, you can reveal the main idea in parts. But prioritize deduction. The technical terms here are induction (writing toward your main idea) and deduction (writing from it). Deductive writing

puts the thesis first. Inductive writing builds to a reveal of the main idea. The approaches can be combined (stay tuned for how), but now we arrive at this rule:

Write deductively for academic readers. (I'll qualify this rule with a "most of the time.") Remember the main point of chapter 1: that academic readers read for use value. They want to know what you're arguing, and how. Be generous to them and offer some help. Tell them quickly what they can expect.*

So get your thesis out there early. Explain how your argument will unfold. (That explanation is your "methodology.") Give the use-driven reader a sense of what is to come so that she can decide how to approach your work.

Tip

Define your key terms early.

Your opening is also the place to define key terms, including any jargon you may be relying on (or that you invented for the occasion). I'll have a lot more to say about jargon in the next chapter. Here, I followed my own advice when I defined "inductive" and "deductive" for my own purposes at the outset.

Make deduction your guiding approach. You don't want to ambush a use-driven reader with a surprise that will make them want to go back and review everything they just read. That's fun after you watch *Sunset Boulevard* or read Agatha Christie's *Murder on the Orient Express*, but academic readers don't want to cover everything all over again. You want to create an efficient reading experience for them.

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* An acronym popular in government communication, which often needs to get to the point right away, is BLUF: "Bottom Line Up Front."

Here's an extended example:

Let's say that you're planning a three-part argument about the Topkapi people of the South Seas.

First, they build their culture on theft.

Second, the origins of Topkapi thievery stem from their attraction to precious stones, whose timeless appeal becomes clear through study of Topkapi myth and legend.

Finally, you'll show that the latter-day disintegration of Topkapi culture results from the tendency of anthropologists who study the Topkapi to steal their jewels from them. You'll base the first two parts of your argument on existing scholarship (which you'll synthesize), but the last point about the klepto-anthropologists is something that you figured out by reading the diaries of anthropologists in an online archive.*

The basic architecture of this (or any) argument depends on coherent structure and sequence. You can present the first part of this argument—or perhaps the first two parts together—to start. After you've explained and supported the first two propositions, you'll be ready to introduce and support the third one. If you started with the third part of the argument, you would be telling the story out of order, and it probably wouldn't make coherent sense to anyone but you.

Try This

Reverse-outlining

If you're wondering whether you've structured your argument soundly, reverse-outline it. That is, outline it after the fact and see whether the outline makes sense to you.

* In case you're wondering, I'm making all of this up. Topkapi is the name of a palace in Istanbul and the eponym for an excellent jewel heist movie from 1964.

A persuasive argument depends on many writerly virtues:

You need to make clear connections between the parts of your argument—which requires not only a sound forensic structure in the first place, but also good transitions.

There needs to be logic (especially a narrative logic) to your approach.

You need to make the boundaries of your own contribution—your idea, as compared to what others have already argued—clear and distinct. Gerald Graff and Cathy Birkenstein have named this move "they say/I say."[2]

"They say/I say" points to a writer's need to show what's at stake. In this imaginary case, you must show why someone else should care about what you've discovered about Topkapi culture. Why does your argument matter? Or, more simply: so what? You therefore need to place your claims into the larger context of what's already known of the Topkapi and certain related subjects that may be relevant to your argument. Some possibilities: the psychology of theft, the allure of jewels, the impulse to collect things, or the dissolution of cultural bonds, to name a few.

Through this presentation, ***you should keep your reader oriented, so she always knows her place in your argument.*** (I described this with the extended metaphor of the chariot ride in chapter 1, and I'll elaborate further presently.) It's not worth saying something if nobody can understand you. And if you can only be understood with difficulty, you will soon exhaust your reader. So explain to your audience what you're doing, either before you start or while you're doing it.

To accomplish all of these things is to tell a story. ***Your story needs two components above all: sound structure and concern for the reader.*** Each of these affects the other. Both of them apply to good writing, from an entire book down to each sentence that it contains.

There are techniques and rules for presenting an argument well. I'll cover some important ones here. The overall structure of my

presentation—the story I'm telling—will move from the larger elements to the smaller ones. I'll consider some of the judgment calls that academic writers make in the beginnings, middles, and ends of their arguments. Throughout, I'll continue my discussion of signposting (which I started at the end of the last chapter, and a technique I'm engaging in right now)—because I want to be deductive here myself. Let's begin with the whole before turning to its parts:

Don't Write It from Beginning to End

The artist Stephen Wiltshire specializes in panoramic cityscapes. After he receives a commission, Wiltshire will view a city during a brief helicopter flight. Then, working entirely from memory, he will fill a room with a meticulously detailed drawing. Because his creation is often filmed in process, it also becomes a kind of performance art. One of the most compelling aspects of the performance is that the artist works from one side of the room to the other, drawing without sketching first, almost like a living computer printer. Wiltshire can do this because his brain works atypically. (He was diagnosed with autism at age three.)[3]

Now imagine writing the way Wiltshire draws. You'd have to start at the beginning and work your way sequentially to the end. In order to do that, you would have to see everything in your head to start with. Most people don't think that way. And when it comes to larger writing projects, most people can't.

Yet so many academic writers try to write from beginning to end. Some of them never stop doing it. One student writer recently confessed to me that he feels guilty if he doesn't have "the perfect paper in my head" when he sits down to write. "My writing comes out messy," he said, "and I feel like I'm doing something wrong." I used to write like that when I was in college, composing in longhand. Because I would constantly double back to add and subtract things, my manuscripts would end up

so cluttered and complicated that I was the only one who could decipher them.

My repeated returns to insert and delete show that I actually could *not* compose from beginning to end. In fact, I was revising as I went along because things kept occurring to me. My writing process unfolded that way because for me—and for most writers—*writing is thinking, not just a record of your thoughts*. Only by actually writing do you figure out what you want to say, and how you should say it.

Try This

Because writing is a disciplined form of thinking, I suggest you plan your writing task by actually writing, not by reflecting on it before you sit down. What surfaces through your pen or keyboard may pleasantly surprise you.

I write because I don't know what I think until I read what I say. —ATTRIBUTED TO FLANNERY O'CONNOR

It follows that you should avoid starting right at the beginning. You can best introduce your work when you can see it whole—but you can't see it whole until you've worked through the middle and brought the end into sight. Here's a compositional tip: after you outline or otherwise get a sense of your overall task, ***start writing at the point where you're most confident of what you want to say***. Keep writing until you're less sure, or you reach a natural resting point. Then look for another point where you feel secure about your ideas, and write from there. Keep creating chunks of exposition in this way. After you have a few, you'll probably start to see how they fit together.

My own writing got easier, faster, and better when I started writing this way. Writing from the middle also helped me take on longer projects—including this book, which I did not write in order.